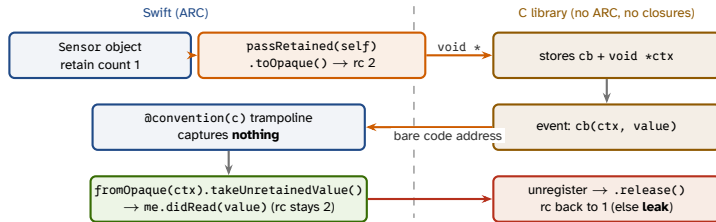


In one line: Swift reads C headers through its built-in **Clang importer**: a header exposed as a **module** (module map; or a **bridging header** in an app target) becomes global Swift functions and types — C scalars map to CInt/CChar..., pointers to Unsafe*Pointer. **C++** (Swift 5.9+, opt-in) imports copyable classes as **value types**. The other way, @c (Swift 6.3; before it the unofficial @_cdecl) exports a Swift function under a C symbol.

C callback + context: the retain has to be balanced by hand



A pointer lives only as long as its scope

s.withCString { p in ... }

time

inside the closure: p valid escaped p = dangling (UB)

c_take(&array) / c_take("text"): implicit pointer is valid for **that one call** — C must not store it

C returns malloc'd char *: copy with String(cString:), then free(p) — the importer does not know who owns it

need it longer? strdup / allocate + own the free, or keep everything inside the closure

Importing C

- App target:** a **bridging header** #imports the headers; visible target-wide, no import. Unsupported in **framework** targets → module map / umbrella header.
- SwiftPM:** a C target's include/ gets a generated module map, or write module CFoo { header "foo.h" export * }; then import CFoo.
- Nullability:** _Nonnull → non-optional, _Nullable → ?, unannotated → IUO ! (NS_ASSUME_NONNULL_BEGIN).
- Not imported:** function-like macros, variadic functions (call the va_list twin via withValist).

How C types map

C	Swift
int · long · char	Int32(CInt) · Int(CLong, LP64) · CChar
const T * / T *	UnsafePointer<T> / UnsafeMutablePointer<T>
const void * / void *	UnsafeRawPointer / UnsafeMutableRawPointer
Foo *, Foo incomplete	OpaquePointer — pass back, never deref
struct	struct: memberwise init + zero init()
T a[4] (field)	tuple (T, T, T, T)
plain enum	struct RawRepresentable + global constants
NS_ENUM / CF_ENUM	Swift enum, non-frozen → @unknown default
NS_CLOSED_ENUM	frozen enum (exhaustive switch)
NS_OPTIONS	OptionSet
#define N 42	let N: Int32 (literals only)
void (*)(int)	@convention(c) (Int32) -> Void

Example — callback with context

```
// C: void sensor_start(void (*cb)(void *, int32_t), void *ctx);
final class Sensor {
    private var ctx: UnsafeMutableRawPointer?
    func start() {
        let c = Unmanaged.passRetained(self).toOpaque() // +1
        sensor_start({ ctx, v in // captures nothing
            Unmanaged<Sensor>.fromOpaque(ctx!)
                .takeUnretainedValue().didRead(v), c) // borrow
        ctx = c }
    }
    func stop() {
        sensor_stop() // C forgets cb first
        if let c = ctx { Unmanaged<Sensor>.fromOpaque(c).release() } }
}
```

Swift → C: @c (6.3) · @_cdecl

@c public func sum(_ a: Int32, _ b: Int32) -> Int32 emits the C symbol sum *and* a declaration in the generated header; @c(MyLib_sum) renames; @c @implementation implements a function a C header already declares. Before 6.3: @_cdecl("sum") — underscored, unofficial, hand-written prototype. Only C-representable types either way.

C++ interop (Swift 5.9 / Xcode 15+)

- Enable:** SwiftPM swiftSettings: [.interoperabilityMode(.Cxx)]; Xcode "C++ and Objective-C Interoperability" = C++/Objective-C++. Opt-in per module, and viral: a module whose interface exposes C++ needs importers to enable it too.
- Copyable class/struct** (copy ctor + dtor) → Swift **value type**: a Swift copy runs the copy ctor, end of lifetime runs the destructor. const methods → non-mutating; others → mutating.
- Reference semantics:** annotate from <swift/bridging> — SWIFT_SHARED_REFERENCE(retain, release) → a Swift class, ARC calls your retain/release; SWIFT_IMMORTAL_REFERENCE → never freed.
- std:** String(cxxStr) / std::string(swiftStr) (copies); std::vector is a RandomAccessCollection (via a typealias); begin/end types iterate in for-in.
- Limits:** class templates only as a specialised using/typedef; a C++ **exception** escaping into Swift **terminates**; Swift → C++ goes through the generated -Swift.h header.

Traps

- ! A closure capturing self as a C function pointer does not compile — context goes through void * + Unmanaged.
- ! passRetained with no release() = leak; passUnretained and the object dies while C holds ctx = use-after-free.
- ! Returning the withCString / withUnsafeBufferPointer pointer out of the closure.
- ! C++ type owning a raw pointer with the default copy ctor → Swift copies it → **double free**. Fix the C++ (rule of 3/5) or make it a shared reference.
- ! A plain C enum is a struct: switch needs default.

Remember

Module in, pointers scoped, context via Unmanaged, C++ copies are real copies.